

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Mauryan Empire: Solved Practice Workbook

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Mauryan Empire: Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard/remedial MCQs precede the PYQ audit; strict ABCD rotation repeats eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are question-specific. Official PYQ option order is never relabelled to fit that rotation.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

These are original questions, not UPSC PYQs. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times.

Q1

Which source is securely contemporary with Ashoka and most directly reveals his public political-ethical voice?

- A. Ashokan edicts
- B. The final redacted Arthashastra
- C. Megasthenes as quoted by Strabo alone
- D. Ashokavadana legends

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The edicts are royal proclamations dated to Ashoka's reign. Named evidence: Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions. Qualification: They reveal intention and self-presentation more securely than implementation. [Q01-A]
- **B:** This option misreads source method: the controlling evidence is Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions, whereas "The final redacted Arthashastra" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q01-B]
- **C:** This option misreads source method: the controlling evidence is Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions, whereas "Megasthenes as quoted by Strabo alone" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q01-C]
- **D:** This option misreads source method: the controlling evidence is Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions, whereas "Ashokavadana legends" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q01-D]

Examiner trap 1: In source method, test the tempting claim "The final redacted Arthashastra" against Major/minor rock and pillar inscriptions; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q2

Which sequence is chronologically correct?

- A. Bindusara -> Chandragupta -> Ashoka, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- B. Chandragupta -> Bindusara -> Ashoka
- C. Chandragupta -> Ashoka -> Bindusara
- D. Ashoka -> Chandragupta -> Bindusara

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads chronology: the controlling evidence is Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction, whereas "Bindusara -> Chandragupta -> Ashoka, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q02-A]
- **B:** The first three major Mauryas were Chandragupta, Bindusara and Ashoka. Named evidence: Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction. Qualification: Exact accession years vary. [Q02-B]

- **C:** This option misreads chronology: the controlling evidence is Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction, whereas "Chandragupta -> Ashoka -> Bindusara" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q02-C]
- **D:** This option misreads chronology: the controlling evidence is Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction, whereas "Ashoka -> Chandragupta -> Bindusara" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q02-D]

Examiner trap 2: In chronology, test the tempting claim "Chandragupta -> Ashoka -> Bindusara" against Puranic/classical/traditional dynastic reconstruction; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q3

What is the safest use of the Arthashastra in a Mauryan answer?

- A. As the official Mauryan civil-service manual
- B. As Megasthenes' lost eyewitness diary
- C. As a theoretical statecraft text whose Mauryan application needs corroboration
- D. As an Ashokan edict collection, applied identically from the north-west to the far south

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads arthashastra: the controlling evidence is Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate, whereas "As the official Mauryan civil-service manual" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q03-A]
- **B:** This option misreads arthashastra: the controlling evidence is Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate, whereas "As Megasthenes' lost eyewitness diary" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q03-B]
- **C:** Current scholarship treats the extant text as theoretical and substantially post-Mauryan/redacted. Named evidence: Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate. Qualification: Earlier ideas within the text may predate its final composition. [Q03-C]
- **D:** This option misreads arthashastra: the controlling evidence is Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate, whereas "As an Ashokan edict collection, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q03-D]

Examiner trap 3: In arthashastra, test the tempting claim "As an Ashokan edict collection" against Upinder Singh Chapter 7; Olivelle/McClish debate; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q4

Why is Megasthenes described as evidence passing through a 'double filter'?

- A. He wrote first in Brahmi and then translated himself into Greek
- B. Two Mauryan kings censored every passage, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record
- C. The Indica survives in two complete manuscripts
- D. His observations were interpreted by him and then selected by later Graeco-Roman writers

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads megasthenes: the controlling evidence is Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny, whereas "He wrote first in Brahmi and then translated himself into Greek" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q04-A]
- **B:** This option misreads megasthenes: the controlling evidence is Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny, whereas "Two Mauryan kings censored every passage, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q04-B]

- **C:** This option misreads megasthenes: the controlling evidence is Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny, whereas "The Indica survives in two complete manuscripts" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q04-C]
- **D:** The original Indica is lost; fragments survive through later authors. Named evidence: Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny. Qualification: Some observations are useful when independently corroborated. [Q04-D]

Examiner trap 4: In megasthenes, test the tempting claim "He wrote first in Brahmi and then translated himself into Greek" against Strabo, Arrian, Diodorus and Pliny; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q5

Which element belongs to the Chandragupta-Seleucus treaty tradition?

- A. Transfer of 500 elephants to Seleucus
- B. Ashoka's surrender of Kalinga
- C. Bindusara's gift of the Sarnath capital
- D. Seleucus becoming governor of Taxila

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Classical sources associate the settlement with territorial transfer and 500 elephants. Named evidence: Graeco-Roman treaty tradition. Qualification: Exact date, marriage clause and territorial control remain debated. [Q05-A]
- **B:** This option misreads seleucus treaty: the controlling evidence is Graeco-Roman treaty tradition, whereas "Ashoka's surrender of Kalinga" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q05-B]
- **C:** This option misreads seleucus treaty: the controlling evidence is Graeco-Roman treaty tradition, whereas "Bindusara's gift of the Sarnath capital" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q05-C]
- **D:** This option misreads seleucus treaty: the controlling evidence is Graeco-Roman treaty tradition, whereas "Seleucus becoming governor of Taxila" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q05-D]

Examiner trap 5: In seleucus treaty, test the tempting claim "Ashoka's surrender of Kalinga" against Graeco-Roman treaty tradition; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q6

Which statement about Bindusara is most defensible?

- A. His Deccan conquest is documented by a contemporary victory inscription
- B. He maintained Hellenistic diplomatic contacts, but the evidence for his conquests is thin
- C. He founded the dynasty after Kalinga, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule
- D. He issued the complete pillar-edict series

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads bindusara: the controlling evidence is Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account, whereas "His Deccan conquest is documented by a contemporary victory inscription" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q06-A]
- **B:** Envoy traditions are firmer than detailed conquest narratives. Named evidence: Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account. Qualification: Most evidence is later and fragmentary. [Q06-B]
- **C:** This option misreads bindusara: the controlling evidence is Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account, whereas "He founded the dynasty after Kalinga, established by a contemporary inscription as an

empire-wide rule" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q06-C]

- **D:** This option misreads bindusara: the controlling evidence is Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account, whereas "He issued the complete pillar-edict series" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q06-D]

Examiner trap 6: In bindusara, test the tempting claim "He founded the dynasty after Kalinga" against Deimachus/Dionysius notices; late Taranatha account; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q7

What does an Ashokan edict find-spot most securely establish?

- A. Uniform direct administration of the entire surrounding region
- B. A permanent Mauryan garrison of known size, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule
- C. Imperial contact and an attempt at communication at or near that location
- D. Absence of all local political institutions

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads imperial extent: the controlling evidence is Distribution of major/minor edicts, whereas "Uniform direct administration of the entire surrounding region" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q07-A]
- **B:** This option misreads imperial extent: the controlling evidence is Distribution of major/minor edicts, whereas "A permanent Mauryan garrison of known size, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q07-B]
- **C:** Find-spots are evidence of message placement and authority claims. Named evidence: Distribution of major/minor edicts. Qualification: Effective control must be tested with regional archaeology and context. [Q07-C]
- **D:** This option misreads imperial extent: the controlling evidence is Distribution of major/minor edicts, whereas "Absence of all local political institutions" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q07-D]

Examiner trap 7: In imperial extent, test the tempting claim "Absence of all local political institutions" against Distribution of major/minor edicts; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q8

Which pairing is correctly associated with a reconstructed Mauryan provincial centre?

- A. Taxila - Kalinga province
- B. Ujjayini - eastern Bengal province
- C. Tosali - north-western province
- D. Suvarnagiri - southern province

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads provinces: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscriptional geography, whereas "Taxila - Kalinga province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q08-A]
- **B:** This option misreads provinces: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscriptional geography, whereas "Ujjayini - eastern Bengal province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q08-B]
- **C:** This option misreads provinces: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscriptional geography, whereas "Tosali - north-western province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q08-C]

- **D:** Suvarnagiri is associated with the southern administrative network. Named evidence: Ashokan inscripational geography. Qualification: The four-province scheme is reconstructed, not a complete official list. [Q08-D]

Examiner trap 8: In provinces, test the tempting claim "Taxila - Kalinga province" against Ashokan inscripational geography; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q9

When the locally held 2025 key is reconciled with Rock Edict III without making the three offices identical, where should the pradeshika-rajuka-yukta triad be placed?

- A. District level
- B. Central court only
- C. Foreign embassy level
- D. Village level

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The locally held official key marks district-level administration. Named evidence: UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III. Qualification: Their precise relative ranks and functions remain debated. [Q09-A]
- **B:** This option misreads officers: the controlling evidence is UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III, whereas "Central court only" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q09-B]
- **C:** This option misreads officers: the controlling evidence is UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III, whereas "Foreign embassy level" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q09-C]
- **D:** This option misreads officers: the controlling evidence is UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III, whereas "Village level" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q09-D]

Examiner trap 9: In officers, test the tempting claim "Central court only" against UPSC 2025 Q19; Rock Edict III; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q10

Which officer category was specially created by Ashoka in his thirteenth consecrated year?

- A. Sannidhatas
- B. Dhamma-mahamattas
- C. Samahartas
- D. Senapatis, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads mahamattas: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict V, whereas "Sannidhatas" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Major Rock Edict V records the new dhamma cadre. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict V. Qualification: They were ethical-welfare officials, not merely Buddhist missionaries. [Q10-B]
- **C:** This option misreads mahamattas: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict V, whereas "Samahartas" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q10-C]
- **D:** This option misreads mahamattas: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict V, whereas "Senapatis, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: In mahamattas, test the tempting claim "Samahartas" against Major Rock Edict V; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q11

Which description best fits the rajuka under Ashoka?

- A. A hereditary village priest only, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception
- B. The keeper of the royal treasury in the Arthashastra
- C. A high field officer with land-measurement associations and later judicial, welfare and dhamma duties
- D. A Greek ambassador to Pataliputra

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads rajuka: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV, whereas "A hereditary village priest only, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q11-A]
- **B:** This option misreads rajuka: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV, whereas "The keeper of the royal treasury in the Arthashastra" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q11-B]
- **C:** The edicts expand rajuka responsibilities beyond a possible surveying origin. Named evidence: Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV. Qualification: The derivation from rajju is suggestive, not conclusive. [Q11-C]
- **D:** This option misreads rajuka: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV, whereas "A Greek ambassador to Pataliputra" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: In rajuka, test the tempting claim "A Greek ambassador to Pataliputra" against Rock Edict III; Pillar Edict IV; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q12

What is the central administrative claim of Rock Edict VI?

- A. All land was owned by the king, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule
- B. The sangha elected provincial governors
- C. Kalinga was restored to independence
- D. Reporters should convey public affairs to the king at any time and place

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads reporting: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict VI, whereas "All land was owned by the king, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q12-A]
- **B:** This option misreads reporting: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict VI, whereas "The sangha elected provincial governors" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q12-B]
- **C:** This option misreads reporting: the controlling evidence is Rock Edict VI, whereas "Kalinga was restored to independence" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q12-C]
- **D:** The edict presents strenuous royal accessibility and rapid reporting. Named evidence: Rock Edict VI. Qualification: It is a command/ideal, not proof of instantaneous empire-wide compliance. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: In reporting, test the tempting claim "All land was owned by the king" against Rock Edict VI; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q13

Which evidence proves Ashoka did not abolish capital punishment?

- A. Pillar Edict IV's three-day respite for condemned prisoners
- B. Rock Edict XII on sectarian concord
- C. The Bhabru recommendation of Buddhist texts
- D. The Sarnath lion capital, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** A respite presupposes the continued death sentence. Named evidence: Pillar Edict IV. Qualification: The edict simultaneously urges fairness and mercy. [Q13-A]
- **B:** This option misreads justice: the controlling evidence is Pillar Edict IV, whereas "Rock Edict XII on sectarian concord" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q13-B]
- **C:** This option misreads justice: the controlling evidence is Pillar Edict IV, whereas "The Bhabru recommendation of Buddhist texts" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q13-C]
- **D:** This option misreads justice: the controlling evidence is Pillar Edict IV, whereas "The Sarnath lion capital, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: In justice, test the tempting claim "Rock Edict XII on sectarian concord" against Pillar Edict IV; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q14

Which conclusion about Ashoka's post-Kalinga military policy is safest?

- A. He dissolved every military unit immediately
- B. He preferred dhamma-vijaya but retained coercive power and did not announce army disbandment
- C. He returned Kalinga and ended taxation
- D. He renounced all judicial punishment, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads military: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "He dissolved every military unit immediately" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Rock Edict XIII combines anti-war remorse with a warning to forest peoples. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. Qualification: The frequency of later coercive operations is unknown. [Q14-B]
- **C:** This option misreads military: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "He returned Kalinga and ended taxation" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q14-C]
- **D:** This option misreads military: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "He renounced all judicial punishment, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: In military, test the tempting claim "He returned Kalinga and ended taxation" against Major Rock Edict XIII; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q15

Which statement about Mauryan land revenue is most accurate?

- A. No agrarian tax existed after Kalinga, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province
- B. One-fourth was uniformly collected everywhere

- C. Rates and actual collection varied across regions and sources
- D. Every plot was legally owned by Ashoka

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads revenue: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms, whereas "No agrarian tax existed after Kalinga, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q15-A]
- **B:** This option misreads revenue: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms, whereas "One-fourth was uniformly collected everywhere" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Rummindei, classical notices and normative one-sixth claims differ. Named evidence: Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms. Qualification: A concession at one village is not an empire-wide schedule. [Q15-C]
- **D:** This option misreads revenue: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms, whereas "Every plot was legally owned by Ashoka" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: In revenue, test the tempting claim "Every plot was legally owned by Ashoka" against Rummindei pillar; Megasthenes fragments; textual norms; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q16

What fiscal measure is recorded at Lumbini in the Rummindei inscription?

- A. Appointment of Seleucus as governor
- B. Creation of six army committees, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record
- C. Abolition of all taxes in Kalinga
- D. Exemption from bali and reduction of bhaga to one-eighth

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads rummindei: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar inscription, whereas "Appointment of Seleucus as governor" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q16-A]
- **B:** This option misreads rummindei: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar inscription, whereas "Creation of six army committees, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q16-B]
- **C:** This option misreads rummindei: the controlling evidence is Rummindei pillar inscription, whereas "Abolition of all taxes in Kalinga" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q16-C]
- **D:** The inscription links pilgrimage, commemoration and a local tax concession. Named evidence: Rummindei pillar inscription. Qualification: The prior rate and precise meaning of bali need caution. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: In rummindei, test the tempting claim "Appointment of Seleucus as governor" against Rummindei pillar inscription; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q17

Which evidence connects Chandragupta's and Ashoka's administrations with the Sudarshana reservoir?

- A. Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription
- B. Major Rock Edict XII, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- C. The Kanaganahalli portrait label
- D. Megasthenes' seven social groups

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The later inscription credits Pushyagupta and Tushaspha in the reservoir's history. Named evidence: Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman. Qualification: It is retrospective evidence written centuries later. [Q17-A]
- **B:** This option misreads irrigation: the controlling evidence is Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman, whereas "Major Rock Edict XII, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q17-B]
- **C:** This option misreads irrigation: the controlling evidence is Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman, whereas "The Kanaganahalli portrait label" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q17-C]
- **D:** This option misreads irrigation: the controlling evidence is Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman, whereas "Megasthenes' seven social groups" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: In irrigation, test the tempting claim "Major Rock Edict XII" against Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q18

Which position best fits the evidence on Mauryan economic control?

- A. A proven total command economy, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- B. Selective and regionally varied state intervention alongside local and private activity
- C. A state with no taxation or regulation
- D. An economy controlled exclusively by Buddhist monasteries

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads economy debate: the controlling evidence is Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts, whereas "A proven total command economy, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Inscriptions show partial interventions; archaeology shows multiple actors. Named evidence: Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts. Qualification: Arthashastra monopolies are prescriptions, not an audited economy. [Q18-B]
- **C:** This option misreads economy debate: the controlling evidence is Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts, whereas "A state with no taxation or regulation" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q18-C]
- **D:** This option misreads economy debate: the controlling evidence is Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts, whereas "An economy controlled exclusively by Buddhist monasteries" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: In economy debate, test the tempting claim "A state with no taxation or regulation" against Rummindei, Sudarshana, towns, coins and crafts; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q19

Which caution applies to Mauryan punch-marked coins?

- A. All were gold dinaras, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception
- B. They ended payments in kind
- C. Symbols may have political or religious meaning, but ruler attribution is often speculative
- D. Every symbol is a dated portrait of Ashoka

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads coinage: the controlling evidence is Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies, whereas "All were gold dinaras, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q19-A]
- **B:** This option misreads coinage: the controlling evidence is Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies, whereas "They ended payments in kind" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q19-B]
- **C:** The motifs came from a broad early-historic cultural pool. Named evidence: Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies. Qualification: Coin use and monetisation remained uneven. [Q19-C]
- **D:** This option misreads coinage: the controlling evidence is Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies, whereas "Every symbol is a dated portrait of Ashoka" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: In coinage, test the tempting claim "Every symbol is a dated portrait of Ashoka" against Silver punch-marked coins and symbol studies; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q20

Which archaeological pair most directly supports a large wooden fortified Pataliputra?

- A. Maski and Brahmagiri
- B. Dhauli and Jaugada, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record
- C. Sanchi and Bharhut
- D. Kumrahar and Bulandibagh

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads urban archaeology: the controlling evidence is Excavations at ancient Patna, whereas "Maski and Brahmagiri" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q20-A]
- **B:** This option misreads urban archaeology: the controlling evidence is Excavations at ancient Patna, whereas "Dhauri and Jaugada, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q20-B]
- **C:** This option misreads urban archaeology: the controlling evidence is Excavations at ancient Patna, whereas "Sanchi and Bharhut" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Kumrahar has a pillared hall; Bulandibagh has wooden palisade remains. Named evidence: Excavations at ancient Patna. Qualification: The hall's exact function and stratigraphy remain debated. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: In urban archaeology, test the tempting claim "Maski and Brahmagiri" against Excavations at ancient Patna; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q21

Megasthenes' seven social groups are best understood as:

- A. A Greek classificatory construction mixing occupations and administrative ranks
- B. The official seven varnas of Mauryan law
- C. An Ashokan census table, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception
- D. Seven Buddhist monastic grades

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** They do not correspond to varna or jati. Named evidence: Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis. Qualification: Some notices still capture heredity/endogamy tendencies. [Q21-A]
- **B:** This option misreads megasthenes society: the controlling evidence is Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis, whereas "The official seven varnas of Mauryan law" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q21-B]
- **C:** This option misreads megasthenes society: the controlling evidence is Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis, whereas "An Ashokan census table, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province; it is also claimed to operate uniformly in every province without exception" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q21-C]
- **D:** This option misreads megasthenes society: the controlling evidence is Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis, whereas "Seven Buddhist monastic grades" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: In megasthenes society, test the tempting claim "The official seven varnas of Mauryan law" against Indica fragments and Thapar's analysis; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q22

Which evidence directly contradicts Megasthenes' claim that India had no slaves?

- A. The Sarnath wheel, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- B. Ashoka's reference to dasas and bhatakas
- C. The Seleucus treaty
- D. The Kalsi elephant alone

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads slavery: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts IX/XI, whereas "The Sarnath wheel, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Rock edicts prescribe courteous conduct toward slaves and servants. Named evidence: Rock Edicts IX/XI. Qualification: Terms cover varied forms of dependence and do not quantify prevalence. [Q22-B]
- **C:** This option misreads slavery: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts IX/XI, whereas "The Seleucus treaty" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q22-C]
- **D:** This option misreads slavery: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts IX/XI, whereas "The Kalsi elephant alone" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: In slavery, test the tempting claim "The Seleucus treaty" against Rock Edicts IX/XI; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q23

What can the Queen's Edict of Karuvaki most securely demonstrate?

- A. Abolition of patriarchal norms, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province
- B. General equality of all Mauryan women
- C. Elite female authority to make recorded pious gifts
- D. Female control of the entire army

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads women: the controlling evidence is Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar, whereas "Abolition of patriarchal norms, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q23-A]
- **B:** This option misreads women: the controlling evidence is Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar, whereas "General equality of all Mauryan women" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q23-B]
- **C:** The inscription records groves, gardens and alms-house gifts. Named evidence: Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar. Qualification: An elite case cannot represent all women. [Q23-C]
- **D:** This option misreads women: the controlling evidence is Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar, whereas "Female control of the entire army" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: In women, test the tempting claim "Female control of the entire army" against Karuvaki's inscription on Allahabad-Kosam pillar; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q24

Which fact most clearly disproves the claim that Ashoka established an exclusively Buddhist state religion?

- A. His pilgrimage to Lumbini
- B. His conquest of Kalinga
- C. His use of Brahmi, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- D. His Barabar cave donations to Ajivikas and calls to honour all sects

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads religious plurality: the controlling evidence is Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII, whereas "His pilgrimage to Lumbini" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q24-A]
- **B:** This option misreads religious plurality: the controlling evidence is Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII, whereas "His conquest of Kalinga" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q24-B]
- **C:** This option misreads religious plurality: the controlling evidence is Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII, whereas "His use of Brahmi, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Patronage and public policy were plural despite personal Buddhism. Named evidence: Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII. Qualification: Plural patronage still operated under paternal monarchy. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: In religious plurality, test the tempting claim "His pilgrimage to Lumbini" against Barabar inscriptions; Rock Edict XII; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q25

Major Rock Edict XIII dates the Kalinga conquest to:

- A. After eight completed years from Ashoka's consecration
- B. The final year of Bindusara
- C. After Ashoka's death, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province
- D. Before Chandragupta's accession

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The war occurred in the ninth regnal year after abhisheka. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. Qualification: The absolute BCE year depends on the reign chronology used. [Q25-A]

- **B:** This option misreads kalinga chronology: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "The final year of Bindusara" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q25-B]
- **C:** This option misreads kalinga chronology: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "After Ashoka's death, treated as a uniform arrangement in every province" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q25-C]
- **D:** This option misreads kalinga chronology: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "Before Chandragupta's accession" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: In kalinga chronology, test the tempting claim "The final year of Bindusara" against Major Rock Edict XIII; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q26

How should the Kalinga casualty numbers be used?

- A. As figures from Megasthenes' Indica
- B. As Ashoka's inscriptional claims, not independently audited statistics
- C. As proof that Kalinga was uninhabited afterward
- D. As modern census-certified totals, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads kalinga casualties: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "As figures from Megasthenes' Indica" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q26-A]
- **B:** The figures are powerful direct royal testimony but not corroborated counts. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XIII. Qualification: Their rhetorical and commemorative context matters. [Q26-B]
- **C:** This option misreads kalinga casualties: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "As proof that Kalinga was uninhabited afterward" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q26-C]
- **D:** This option misreads kalinga casualties: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XIII, whereas "As modern census-certified totals, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: In kalinga casualties, test the tempting claim "As proof that Kalinga was uninhabited afterward" against Major Rock Edict XIII; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q27

Why are Dhauli and Jaugada especially important?

- A. They contain the Sarnath lion capital
- B. They are the only Kharoshthi sites, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule
- C. They preserve Separate Kalinga Edicts on post-conquest administration and confidence-building
- D. They record Chandragupta's Seleucus treaty

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads separate edicts: the controlling evidence is Separate Rock Edicts I-II, whereas "They contain the Sarnath lion capital" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q27-A]
- **B:** This option misreads separate edicts: the controlling evidence is Separate Rock Edicts I-II, whereas "They are the only Kharoshthi sites, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule" conflicts with the

required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q27-B]

- **C:** Their regional text replaces parts of the standard major-edict sequence. Named evidence: Separate Rock Edicts I-II. Qualification: Policy orders do not prove complete implementation. [Q27-C]
- **D:** This option misreads separate edicts: the controlling evidence is Separate Rock Edicts I-II, whereas "They record Chandragupta's Seleucus treaty" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: In separate edicts, test the tempting claim "They record Chandragupta's Seleucus treaty" against Separate Rock Edicts I-II; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q28

Which formulation best defines Ashoka's public dhamma?

- A. The complete Buddhist monastic Vinaya
- B. A modern secular constitution, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record
- C. A programme of compulsory conversion
- D. An imperial social ethic with Buddhist roots, focused on conduct, non-injury, welfare and concord

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads dhamma: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts, whereas "The complete Buddhist monastic Vinaya" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q28-A]
- **B:** This option misreads dhamma: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts, whereas "A modern secular constitution, with no regional or chronological variation in the surviving record" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q28-B]
- **C:** This option misreads dhamma: the controlling evidence is Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts, whereas "A programme of compulsory conversion" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q28-C]
- **D:** The edicts address everyday relations and multiple sects. Named evidence: Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts. Qualification: Dhamma remained paternal and tied to merit/heaven. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: In dhamma, test the tempting claim "The complete Buddhist monastic Vinaya" against Rock Edicts VII, IX, XI, XII and pillar edicts; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q29

Major Rock Edict XII goes beyond passive tolerance by urging:

- A. Restraint, listening and growth in the essentials of all sects
- B. Election of monks as governors
- C. Destruction of every non-Buddhist shrine
- D. End of royal patronage, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The edict seeks dialogue and mutual understanding. Named evidence: Major Rock Edict XII. Qualification: Royal exhortation does not prove conflict ended. [Q29-A]
- **B:** This option misreads religious concord: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XII, whereas "Election of monks as governors" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q29-B]
- **C:** This option misreads religious concord: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XII, whereas "Destruction of every non-Buddhist shrine" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of

certainty. [Q29-C]

- **D:** This option misreads religious concord: the controlling evidence is Major Rock Edict XII, whereas "End of royal patronage, established by a contemporary inscription as an empire-wide rule" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: In religious concord, test the tempting claim "Election of monks as governors" against Major Rock Edict XII; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q30

Which inscription most directly describes Ashoka as a lay follower who became more zealous gradually?

- A. The Sohgaure plaque
- B. Minor Rock Edict I
- C. The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman
- D. Major Rock Edict XIII alone

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads personal buddhism: the controlling evidence is Minor Rock Edict I, whereas "The Sohgaure plaque" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Minor Rock Edict I gives a staged account of lay affiliation and effort. Named evidence: Minor Rock Edict I. Qualification: The wording varies across versions. [Q30-B]
- **C:** This option misreads personal buddhism: the controlling evidence is Minor Rock Edict I, whereas "The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q30-C]
- **D:** This option misreads personal buddhism: the controlling evidence is Minor Rock Edict I, whereas "Major Rock Edict XIII alone" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: In personal buddhism, test the tempting claim "The Junagadh inscription of Rudradaman" against Minor Rock Edict I; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q31

Which script-language pairing is correct?

- A. Kandahar - Brahmi only
- B. Mansehra - Tamil-Brahmi only
- C. Shahbazgarhi - Kharoshthi and north-western Prakrit
- D. Girnar - Greek only, applied identically from the north-west to the far south

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads scripts: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscription corpus, whereas "Kandahar - Brahmi only" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q31-A]
- **B:** This option misreads scripts: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscription corpus, whereas "Mansehra - Tamil-Brahmi only" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra use Kharoshthi. Named evidence: Ashokan inscription corpus. Qualification: Script choice does not by itself identify ethnicity. [Q31-C]
- **D:** This option misreads scripts: the controlling evidence is Ashokan inscription corpus, whereas "Girnar - Greek only, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: In scripts, test the tempting claim "Girnar - Greek only" against Ashokan inscription corpus; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

Q32

Which is the most defensible model of the Mauryan state?

- A. A purely symbolic realm without taxation or officers
- B. Identical administration in every village
- C. A modern unitary nation-state, applied identically from the north-west to the far south
- D. A strong but differentiated empire with regionally and functionally varied control

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** This option misreads centralisation: the controlling evidence is Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate, whereas "A purely symbolic realm without taxation or officers" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q32-A]
- **B:** This option misreads centralisation: the controlling evidence is Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate, whereas "Identical administration in every village" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q32-B]
- **C:** This option misreads centralisation: the controlling evidence is Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate, whereas "A modern unitary nation-state, applied identically from the north-west to the far south" conflicts with the required chronology, source class, geography or degree of certainty. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Provinces and officers show capacity; communication and regional archaeology show variation. Named evidence: Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate. Qualification: The balance may differ by reign and zone. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: In centralisation, test the tempting claim "A purely symbolic realm without taxation or officers" against Edicts, archaeology, Thapar/Fussman/Sugandhi debate; do not convert a bounded inference into a universal fact.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ AND KEY DISCIPLINE

- Five direct routed Prelims PYQs use locally held official-paper text: 2019 Q8, 2020 Q30, 2022 Q60, 2022 Q91 and 2025 Q19.
- The official 2025 Set-A key is held locally; Q19 is **B - district-level administration**.
- Official 2019-2022 keys are not held locally. Their solutions below are labelled inferred/text-based, never official.
- The 2023 stupa Prelims item and 2020 rock-cut Mains item are adjacent, cross-owned Art and Culture practice, not direct Topic 14 routing.
- UPSC publishes no official descriptive model answers.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2019 Q8: Ranyo Ashoka portrait

Question: In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka) mentioned along with the stone portrait of Ashoka?

- (A) Kanganahalli
- (B) Sanchi
- (C) Shahbazgarhi
- (D) Sohgaure

Answer/status: A - Kanganahalli

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official question paper controls wording; the official key is not held in the repository.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Kanaganahalli	Raya/Ranyo Asoko label with royal reliefs	Correct identification	Reliefs are 2nd-3rd century CE memories, not lifetime portraits
Sanchi	Later reliefs interpreted as Ashoka scenes	Important memory of Ashoka	The named inscription in this PYQ is not Sanchi
Shahbazgarhi	Kharoshthi Major Rock Edicts	Ashokan epigraphy	Not a portrait-relief site
Sohgaura	Debated early-historic famine/storehouse plaque	Administrative-history evidence	Not a portrait-relief inscription

Solved analysis

- The Kanaganahalli stupa excavations produced limestone reliefs labelled 'Raya Asoko' and showing a king with a queen and attendants.
- The sculptures were made centuries after Ashoka; they reveal his early iconic memory in Buddhist art rather than his actual appearance.
- Elimination works by separating an art-memory site from rock-edict and administrative-inscription sites.

Why this earns marks: It gives the key, identifies the labelled artefact, distinguishes representation from eyewitness portraiture, and eliminates each distractor by evidence class.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "In which of the following relief sculpture inscriptions is 'Ranyo Ashoka' (King Ashoka)..."", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2020 Q30: sectarian concord inscription

Question: Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever praises his religious sect or blames other sects out of excessive devotion to his own sect, with the view of glorifying his own sect, he rather injures his own sect very severely'?

- (A) Ashoka
- (B) Samudragupta
- (C) Harshavardhana
- (D) Krishnadeva Raya

Answer/status: A - Ashoka

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The wording is from the local 2020 official paper; repository routing records no local official key.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Named source	Major Rock Edict XII	Restraint in praising one's sect and condemning others	Translation wording varies
Positive demand	Growth in essentials and listening to other sects	Concord exceeds passive toleration	Royal exhortation is not proof of harmony
Ashoka's position	Honours all sects while personally Buddhist	Separates public policy from personal faith	Paternal royal authority remains
Distractors	Prashasti/court traditions of later rulers	Different genres and periods	Religious patronage alone does not identify the quotation

Solved analysis

- The quotation condenses Ashoka's Major Rock Edict XII.
- The decisive phrase is not generic tolerance but the injury caused to one's own sect by excessive self-praise and denunciation of others.
- A high-quality explanation adds that Ashoka sought dialogue and growth in the essentials of all sects, not a modern secular state.

Why this earns marks: It anchors the answer to a named edict and explains the ethical-political content instead of relying on ruler recognition alone.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...'" as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Who among the following rulers advised his subjects through this inscription: 'Whosoever...'", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q60: Arthashastra and slavery

Question: According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, consider: (1) a person could be a slave as a result of judicial punishment; (2) if a female slave bore her master a son, she was legally free; (3) such a son fathered by the master had the legal status of the master's son. Which are correct?

- (A) 1 and 2 only
- (B) 2 and 3 only
- (C) 1 and 3 only
- (D) 1, 2 and 3

Answer/status: B - 2 and 3 only

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held. The key follows the text-based legal distinction.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Judicial punishment wording	Not accepted in the keyed text interpretation	Translations and slavery categories require care
Statement 2	Freedom of the mother after bearing master's son	Correct Arthashastra provision	Normative law, not social census
Statement 3	Status of the son	Correct legal provision	Does not establish frequency or empire-wide implementation
Historical use	Arthashastra slavery rules	Evidence for legal-political thought	Not transparent Mauryan practice

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 form a connected legal rule on manumission and filial status.
- The question asks 'according to the Arthashastra'; it does not ask what Ashoka's administration practised.
- The package therefore solves the objective demand while preserving the composition/redaction and prescription caveat.

Why this earns marks: It demonstrates demand fidelity: text-specific answer first, then source criticism without allowing the caveat to obscure the key.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, consider: (1) a person could be a slave as a result..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "According to Kautilya's Arthashastra, consider: (1) a person could be a slave as a result...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2022 Q91: Major Rock Edict sites

Question: Consider the pairs: Dhauli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-Karnataka. How many are correctly matched?

- (A) Only one pair
- (B) Only two pairs
- (C) Only three pairs
- (D) All four pairs

Answer/status: B - Only two pairs

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. The local official paper is held; the official key is not held.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Dhuli	Odisha	Correct; Separate Kalinga Edicts replace part of standard set	Modern district references can change
Erragudi	Andhra Pradesh	Correct; Major and minor rock-edict context	Spelling Yerragudi/Erragudi varies
Jaugada	Odisha, not Madhya Pradesh	Incorrect pair	Kalinga regional context
Kalsi	Uttarakhand, not Karnataka	Incorrect pair	North Indian Himalayan-foothill route

Solved analysis

- Only Dhuli-Odisha and Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh are correct.
- A map-first method prevents phonetic or vague-regional guessing.
- Dhuli and Jaugada should be mentally paired as Kalinga sites; Kalsi belongs to Uttarakhand.

Why this earns marks: It supplies exact state corrections and links geography to inscription category, creating durable elimination memory.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the pairs: Dhuli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the pairs: Dhuli-Odisha; Erragudi-Andhra Pradesh; Jaugada-Madhya Pradesh; Kalsi-...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified Prelims PYQ - 2025 Q19: Pradeshika, Rajuka and Yukta

Question: Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important officers at which level?

- (A) Village-level administration
- (B) District-level administration
- (C) Provincial administration
- (D) Central administration

Answer/status: B - District-level administration

Verification: OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. Local UPSC 2025 Series-A key marks Q19 as B.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Pradeshika	Rock Edict III tour context	District-level field officer	Exact rank/function not identical to modern district magistrate
Rajuka	Land-measurement hypothesis; justice/welfare/dhamma	High field responsibility	Etymology is not a complete job description
Yukta	Directed duties and tours	Subordinate/executive accounting-administrative role	Context changes
Collective context	Five-year tours for dhamma and other purposes	District-level administration	No single modern hierarchy should be forced

Solved analysis

- The official answer is district-level administration.
- Rock Edict III groups the three for quinquennial tours, while other inscriptions expand rajuka duties.
- The examination fact should be retained without pretending that the three offices were identical.

Why this earns marks: It uses the official local key, names the edict context, and protects against over-modernising ancient titles.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Ashokan inscriptions suggest that the 'Pradeshika', 'Rajuka' and 'Yukta' were important...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified adjacent Prelims PYQ - 2023 Q42: stupa origin and function

Question: With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin; (2) Stupa was generally a repository of relics; (3) Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition. How many statements are correct?

- (A) Only one
- (B) Only two
- (C) All three
- (D) None

Answer/status: B - Only two

Verification: INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included because Ashokan stupa patronage is a Topic 14 subtheme.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Statement 1	Funerary mound tradition predates/exceeds Buddhism	Incorrect	Buddhism transformed and popularised the form
Statement 2	Relic enshrinement	Correct for many Buddhist stupas	Not every stupa necessarily held relics
Statement 3	Votive and commemorative roles	Correct	Functions changed by site and period
Mauryan link	Sanchi brick core; Nigali Sagar enlargement	Ashoka's major patronage phase	Later visible additions must be dated separately

Solved analysis

- Statements 2 and 3 are correct; the stupa form was not exclusively Buddhist in origin.
- Ashoka's significance lies in patronage, enlargement, commemoration and popularisation, not invention of the mound.
- Sanchi's Mauryan brick core and later gateways provide the crucial chronology trap.

Why this earns marks: It answers the objective demand and ties the result to a precise Mauryan architectural chronology.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "With reference to ancient India, consider: (1) the concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin;...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Verified adjacent Mains PYQ - 2020 GS-I Q1: rock-cut architecture

Question: Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss with reference to rock-cut architecture. (10 marks, 150 words)

Answer/status: Model answer

Verification: VERIFIED QUESTION from the local official 2020 GS-I paper. Primary ownership is Indian Art and Culture; included for Barabar and Mauryan beginnings.

Evidence / elimination matrix

Claim/option	Named evidence	Significance	Limitation
Mauryan beginning	Barabar caves; Ashokan Ajivika dedications	Imperial patronage, ascetic space and rock technology	Lomash Rishi itself has no Ashokan dedication
Formal idea	Hut/wooden forms translated into rock	Tradition reworked through durable medium	Chronology and patronage vary
Later expansion	Buddhist chaitya-vihara complexes such as Bhaja/Ajanta	Ritual movement, congregational worship and monastic residence	Later evidence should not be backdated
Plural traditions	Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical caves	Philosophy and patronage shaped form and iconography	Material, labour and politics also matter

Solved analysis

- **THESIS:** Rock-cut architecture materialised Indian traditions of renunciation, sacred presence, congregation and patronage, while craftsmen transformed earlier wooden forms into enduring stone.
- **MODEL:** The Mauryan Barabar caves provide the earliest surviving imperial stage: Ashoka's inscriptions dedicate highly polished caves to Ajivikas, linking royal patronage with ascetic withdrawal. The Lomash Rishi facade imitates a timber-and-thatch entrance, showing translation rather than mere copying. Later Buddhist chaityas organised worship around a stupa and circumambulation, while viharas institutionalised monastic residence; Jain and Brahmanical caves adapted the medium to their own sacred narratives and icons. Yet philosophy alone did not cut rock: court or mercantile patronage, quarrying skill, labour and route-linked monastic economies made these monuments possible. Thus ideas supplied purpose and symbolism, while technology and institutions shaped the realised form.
- **VERDICT:** Rock-cut architecture is evidence of interaction among doctrine, ritual, patronage, material technology and landscape.

Why this earns marks: It directly discusses the role of philosophy/tradition, uses Barabar and later comparators, adds material causation, and avoids calling every early cave Buddhist.

PYQ discipline: The printed official paper controls wording and question number. An unavailable local key is never presented as officially verified.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The model answer or solved analysis above is the executable content base; retain its named evidence, causal links and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic summary.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

SIX ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS - EXACT COUNT

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 1 - Source criticism

Question: Why must the Mauryan Empire be reconstructed through a source matrix rather than by merging all texts at face value? (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (125 words):

Mauryan history survives in archives with different dates and purposes. Ashoka's edicts are contemporary royal communications: they reveal titles, dhamma, Kalinga and some officers, but intention is clearer than implementation. Archaeology at Pataliputra, Taxila, Sanchi and Barabar supplies material context without automatically naming a ruler or office. Megasthenes offers observations only through later Graeco-Roman quotation, creating a double filter. The Arthashastra illuminates statecraft and political economy, yet its layered redaction prevents its use as Chandragupta's verbatim manual. Puranic, Buddhist and Jain traditions preserve dynastic and religious memory but reflect late transmission and sectarian aims. Therefore, reconstruction requires convergence: claim, named source or site, inference and qualification. The Mauryan state becomes clearer not by flattening disagreement, but by asking what each source can and cannot prove.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 2 - Dhamma and Buddhism

Question: Explain why Ashoka's dhamma cannot be equated either with Buddhism alone or with modern secularism. (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (129 words):

Ashoka was personally Buddhist, but his public dhamma addressed a diverse empire. Minor Rock Edict I, the Bhabru Edict, Lumbini and Sangha-related records support his Buddhist commitment. The major public edicts instead emphasize respect for parents and elders, humane treatment of servants, generosity to Brahmanas and Shramanas, restraint in killing, self-control and sectarian concord. Major Rock Edict XII urges listening and restraint in praising one's own sect, not doctrinal conversion. Dhamma thus drew moral energy from Ashoka's faith while operating as a wider ethic of paternal kingship and imperial integration. It was not modern secularism either: it used merit, heaven and royal moral supervision rather than equal constitutional citizenship. The safest conclusion is Buddhist-rooted, publicly plural and politically useful, but neither a Buddhist catechism nor a modern rights charter.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 1 - Administration

Question: Examine Mauryan administration through central, provincial and local levels, while assessing the limits of the evidence. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (167 words):

Mauryan administration combined royal concentration with delegated and regionally varied execution. At the centre, the king appointed officers, commanded the army, judged and received reports. Rock Edict VI presents *patedakas* bringing business at any time, while ministers and a council are more fully reconstructed from textual traditions. Provincial nodes at Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri were linked to princes or governors, although the four-centre scheme is reconstructed rather than complete. Rock Edict III groups *pradeshikas*, *rajukas* and *yuktas* in five-year tours; the official 2025 key places them at district level. *Rajukas* later received justice and welfare responsibilities, while *mahamattas* formed a broad high-official category with specialised portfolios. Villages, towns, guilds, householders and local elites mediated assessment, information and compliance. The army and reporting network gave coercive capacity, but Megasthenes' committees survive through later quotation and *Arthashastra* portfolios remain prescriptive. Thus the empire had strong hierarchical capacity without one proven universal organisation chart: administration was centralised in appointment and strategic purpose, differentiated in function, region and local penetration.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 2 - Kalinga and kingship

Question: Analyse how the Kalinga war altered Ashoka's conception and practice of kingship without making him a complete pacifist. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (142 words):

Major Rock Edict XIII places Kalinga after eight completed years of Ashoka's consecrated reign. Its importance lies not only in large royal claims of deportation and death, but in recognition of suffering among families, Brahmanas, Shramanas, servants and dependants. Ashoka recast victory as a moral problem and preferred *dhamma-vijaya* to repeated armed expansion. The Separate Kalinga Edicts instructed provincial officers to reduce arbitrary imprisonment and win confidence; tours, *dhamma-mahamattas*, welfare and proclamation enlarged paternal kingship. Yet Kalinga remained incorporated, the army was not abolished, punishment and the death penalty continued, and Rock Edict XIII warned forest peoples that the king retained power to punish. Minor Rock Edict I suggests Buddhist commitment before Kalinga, so the war was not an instant first conversion. Kalinga redirected an existing imperial monarchy from celebratory conquest toward remorse, restraint and moral legitimation while sovereignty and deterrence survived.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 1 - Territorial integration

Question: Was the Mauryan Empire uniformly centralised? Evaluate through inscriptional geography, administration and communication. (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (174 words):

The Mauryan Empire achieved unprecedented integration, but uniform centralisation is not the best model. Pataliputra and the middle Ganga basin formed the metropolitan core. Provincial nodes associated with Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali and Suvarnagiri connected the court to the north-west, west, Kalinga and south through princes, officials and routes. Inscriptions from Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra to Dhauli, Jaugada, Maski and Erragudi demonstrate wide communication. Regional Prakrits, Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek and Aramaic show adaptation rather than sameness. Mahamattas, pradeshikas, rajukas and yuktas, reports and tours indicate hierarchical supervision; revenue and armies show real capacity. However, a find-spot proves contact and authority claim, not identical enforcement. Tamil polities and Tambapanni are neighbours or outreach zones, not demonstrated provinces; forest peoples receive warning rather than proof of routine incorporation. Slow movement, ecological diversity, local intermediaries and uneven archaeology limited direct penetration. Centralisation was therefore functional and geographical: strong in appointment, fiscal-military mobilisation and strategic corridors, but mediated in local administration and frontier control. The Mauryan polity was a layered empire, neither a modern unitary state nor merely symbolic sovereignty.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 2 - Political economy

Question: Critically examine Mauryan state control over agriculture, revenue, crafts, trade and strategic resources. (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Obey the directive; organise the response by mechanism or comparison; attach named evidence to each claim; retain one explicit source or regional qualification.

Model answer (170 words):

Mauryan power rested on mobilising surplus, yet the evidence does not support a universal command economy. Agriculture was the main fiscal base. Sources mention bhaga, bali, tolls, fines and labour obligations; Rummindei records a local bali exemption and bhaga reduction to one-eighth, disproving a single realised rate. Rudradaman's later Junagadh inscription links Pushyagupta and Tushaspha with Sudarshana, suggesting state-supported irrigation but not one central water department. The Arthashastra describes crown land, superintendents, mines, forests, salt, trade, workshops and standards. These provisions reveal a powerful model, but the text is layered and prescriptive. Archaeology and punch-marked coins show crafts, towns and circulation; most coins do not name Mauryan rulers, while barter, kind payments and credit persisted. Merchants, artisans, shrenis, households and communities remained active agents. Roads, security, standards and strategic-resource regulation could facilitate exchange as well as extract revenue. Intervention was probably deepest near capitals, provincial nodes, routes, mines, forests and royal establishments. The best verdict is selective high capacity within a mixed, regionally varied economy, not total monopoly or laissez-faire.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim/evidence units -> counterpoint or limit -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Add one correctly labelled mini-flow or source matrix only if time permits; do not trade evidence for decorative detail.